



INTERCULTURAL COMMUNICATION & TRAINING (ICT) TOOLKIT



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Introduction

A simple colloquial definition of culture is “how we get things done around here.” We might be used to describe a group of people with shared characteristics such as race, ethnicity, gender, sexuality, nationality, or the intersections of one or more of those identities. *Get things done* might refer to how the group communicates, builds rapport, forms families and working relationships, accomplishes goals, solves problems, gives feedback, and more. Two questions might arise during this process. Why pay attention to culture? Why build intercultural competence? Developing intercultural communication skills is vital to thrive in multicultural environments, to teach and reach diverse audiences, and to lead successfully in diverse institutions and communities. Simply put, “cultural competence is the linchpin to ensure inclusion” (Winters 2013).

A few other definitions of culture and intercultural competence are worth considering, which include:

- “Culture: All knowledge and values shared by a group.” (AAC&U 2009)
- “Culture can be defined as the behavioral interpretation of how a group lives out its values to survive and thrive, or, alternately, the unwritten practices, rules, and norms of a group.” (Winters 2017)
- “The external outcome [of intercultural competence] can be described as essentially ‘behaving and communicating appropriately and effectively in intercultural situations.’” (Deardorff 2006)
- “...there is an emerging consensus around what constitutes intercultural competence, which is most often viewed as a set of cognitive, affective, and behavioral skills and characteristics that support effective and appropriate interaction in a variety of cultural contexts.” (Bennett 2009)

Many international educators use the AAC&U *Intercultural Knowledge and Competence VALUE Rubric* as a guide to creating intercultural training. Successful intercultural training will impart and educate knowledge (cultural self-awareness and knowledge of cultural worldview frameworks), train and give room for practice of skills (empathy and verbal/nonverbal communication), and foster helpful attitudes (curiosity and openness).

How to Use This Toolkit

The Intercultural Communication & Training (ICT) Toolkit is a practical document that is meant to be applied. You may find it helpful to read it straight through, or you may skip around to where your interests lead you or as the need arises. You may already have a plan to implement a certain kind of training that can be further supplemented with the information provided here. The ICT Toolkit is not designed to make you an expert

intercultural trainer, but it suggests first steps for starting a new phase in your intercultural training journey.

In using the ICT Toolkit, you will be able to:

- Plan and implement a basic program of intercultural training.
- Design and deliver a basic intercultural training workshop.
- Understand and apply common ICT training methodologies.

Audiences

While the ICT Toolkit was written primarily for the international education professional who is relatively new to the field, it may be useful for anyone who wants to understand and apply the basics of creating and delivering intercultural training, including:

- graduate students exploring career options in international education;
- early career, pivoting, or seasoned professionals adding intercultural work to their repertoires;
- senior officials leading but not necessarily performing this work; and
- practitioners with diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) experience interested in adding international-intercultural perspectives and methods.

Note that the ICT Toolkit can and should be applied to your own circumstances. Faculty and teaching assistants may apply intercultural concepts in the classroom or with research groups. Staff and student leaders might apply this in their offices, advising practice, orientation, and campus life. Program providers might utilize this resource in their practice. Students in transition programs may also benefit from intercultural training during orientation and first year experience programs. Readers should choose objectives, examples, and points of emphasis according to their own context.

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Cultural Values

One of the ways that International Educators train and teach regarding culture differences is to focus on cultural values. There are a number of excellent books that discuss cultural value differences, but one of the easiest to digest is Storti's (2017) *Understanding the World's Cultures: A Practical Guide*. In the book, Storti explores four building blocks of culture and where certain cultures fall on the proposed spectrum for each:

- Concept of Self (Individualist and Collectivist)
- Personal vs. Societal Responsibility (Universalist and Particularist)
- Concept of Time (Monochronic and Polychronic)
- Locus of Control (Internal and External)

Based on Storti's paradigm, Individualist cultures value self-sufficiency and promotion based on output, while Collectivist cultures value harmony and saving face. Universalist cultures prioritize rules and minimize ingroup/outgroup distinctions whereas Particularist cultures prioritize ingroups and believe that rules are contextual. Monochronic cultures view time as a commodity while Polychronic cultures see time as a tool to be adjusted as needed. Internal cultures are solutions oriented while external cultures are more fatalistic. Participants are encouraged to analyze their own values and then think about how others' values may be different.

Hofstede's (2001) [Six Cultural Dimensions](#) are a similar set of value differences that were developed for the workplace:

- Power Distance Index
- Individualism vs Collectivism
- Masculinity vs Femininity (or Competitive vs Cooperation)
- Uncertainty Avoidance Index
- Long-term Orientation vs Short-Term Normative Orientation
- Indulgence vs Restraint

Power Distance is about how willing people are to accept unequal distributions of power. Hofstede's Individualism vs Collectivism dimension is the same as that presented by Storti. The Masculinity vs Femininity dimension is also known as the Competitive vs Cooperation dimension. Uncertainty Avoidance is how cultures deal with not knowing the future. Long-term Orientation is also known as flexhumility. Cultures that are flexhumble adapt easily and focus on long term goals rather than short-term gains. Short-term Normative cultures, on the other hand, value maintaining traditions and view societal change with suspicion. Finally, Indulgence vs Restraint is about indulging in or controlling desires.

Other researchers have also explored cultural dimensions through a variety of lenses that may be helpful to consider in expanding practice, with several utilizing continuum frameworks.

Trompenaars and Hampden-Turner (1997) have a framework placing cultures on a continuum with seven dimensions comprised of comparative opposing descriptors:

- Universalism vs Particularism
- Individualism vs Communitarianism
- Specific vs Diffuse
- Neutral vs Emotional
- Achievement vs Ascription
- Sequential vs Synchronous Time
- Internal vs Outer Direction

Meyer (2014) utilizes an eight-scale model for cultures, providing the following categorizations:

- Communicating (low-context vs high-context)
- Evaluating (direct vs indirect negative feedback)
- Persuading (principles-first vs applications-first)
- Leading (egalitarian vs hierarchical)
- Deciding (consensual vs top-down)
- Trusting (task-based vs relationship-based)
- Disagreeing (confrontational vs avoids confrontation)
- Scheduling (linear-time vs flexible time)

In combination with these different frameworks for thinking through the concepts, Storti and Hofstede provide a number of resources and activities to use with students or other participants. Storti's book is a workbook with available exercises and Hofstede's (2002) coauthored book has many useful exercises, including an exercise called "What Do You See?" in which participants interpret vague pictures and then think about why they interpreted the pictures as they did.

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Identity

There is no one simple definition of identity. In the dictionary, as in the literature, identity seems to be many things and divided into many spheres. Taken from the perspective of the social scientist, identity seems to speak to how a person may perceive themselves within society or how they derive respect and dignity. As posited by James D. Fearon (1999), a political scientist at Stanford University,

“identity” is presently used in two linked senses, which may be termed “social” and “personal.” In the former sense, an “identity” refers simply to a social category, a set of persons marked by a label and distinguished by rules deciding membership and (alleged) characteristic features or attributes. In the second sense of personal identity, an identity is some distinguishing characteristic (or characteristics) that a person takes a special pride in or views as socially consequential but more-or-less unchangeable.

Identity can be broken down into several focal areas, some of which are:

- Racial identity
- Cultural identity
- National identity
- Sexual identity
- Gender identity
- Religious identity

Racial identity, cultural identity, and national identity may at times overlap but are never seen as conflating ideas. For instance, Nettleford (1998) chides many black Jamaicans for perpetuating racist ideals and identifying only with their nationality and not their race. This, he believed, was and is a political ideal espoused by leaders over the centuries that Jamaica and the Caribbean are nonracial nations made up of peoples from all over the world, thus ignoring and minimizing ideas of racial identity. The treatment of the ideas of race and racial identity in the Caribbean is a significant departure from the social constructs that exist in other parts of the world where race is an identifier, classifier, vehicle for advancement, or deterrent.

In addition, gender identity and sexual identity are similar but not the same. Whereas sexual identity is biological, gender identity has to do with how one perceives themselves—male, female, or nonbinary, for example. Sexual identity and the biology of it is said to incorporate the rules of the society in which it exists (Ross and Rapp 1997).

There is also the idea of intersecting identities. This does not simply mean people seeing themselves as more than one thing or identifying as more than one element of “identity.”

Intersecting identities, however, has everything to do with people being and identifying as more than a particular race or sexual orientation and how this identification interacts with power structures—exemplified in the following quote:

For each of us, our various identities impact our daily lives, affecting how we perceive the world and how the world perceives us. When we look at how our identities intersect, we see the unique lived experiences—of ourselves and others—through the lens of privilege, oppression, power, and marginalization. (Ramos and Brassel 2020)

There are many activities that encourage participants to reflect on their salient identities. The [Circles of My Multicultural Self](#) exercise is one such activity in which participants consider what they would ascribe as the most important dimension/s of their own identities as well as examining how relevant stereotypes can be interpreted as sources of both pride and humiliation. Paseo's [Circles of Identity](#) provide another activity model.

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Conflict Navigation

In the ICT context, having knowledge, skills, and abilities to navigate conflict is imperative. Be it group, ethnic, individual, or any other correlation, conflict is inevitable. Thomas Crum (1998) stated it ever so clearly,

Conflict is natural, neither positive nor negative, it just is. Conflict is an interference pattern of energies. Nature uses conflicts as its primary motivator for change, creating beautiful beaches, canyons, mountains, and pearls. It's not whether you have conflict in your life; it's what you do with conflict that makes a difference. Conflict is not a contest. Winning and losing are goals for games, not conflicts. Learning, growing, and cooperating are goals for resolving conflicts. Conflicts can be seen as a gift of energy, in which neither side loses and a new dance is created. Resolving conflict is rarely about who is right, it is about acknowledgement and appreciation of differences. Conflict begins within. As we unhitch the burden of belief systems and heighten our perceptions, we love more fully and freely.

Resources on conflict transformation and nonviolent communication for international educators are abundant and accessible. Crum's (1998) *The Magic of Conflict*, for example, does a deep dive into both individual and work-related conflict (internal and external). The [Karuna Center for Peacebuilding](#) also offers a well-rounded, free downloadable training guide containing tools and activities for navigating conflict in a global context including materials for facilitators.

Below are a few examples of successful initiatives and programs in conflict transformation:

- [Healing Our Communities](#) focuses on trauma healing, youth leadership, and community dialogue.
- [Conflict Kitchen](#) uses food to engage the public in dialogue on international conflict.
- [See Other Sides](#) utilizes participatory, experiential activities as well as the arts to navigate conflict.
- [CONTACT](#) is an SIT Graduate Institute workshop that uses participatory, experiential activities to build skills and awareness in conflict prevention, conflict mapping and analysis, interventions in conflict environments, social change strategies, multicultural sensitivity and communication, interethnic dialogue, active nonviolence, group facilitation, negotiation, mediation, and reconciliation.

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Culture Shock

Culture shock is a feeling of disorientation, confusion, or anxiousness experienced by someone who is subjected to an unfamiliar culture, way of life, or set of norms and attitudes. Factors that can contribute to culture shock include climate, language, social roles, “rules” of behavior, values, and long-distance relationship stressors. Almost every person who spends time in a new place will feel a varying sense of culture shock and it is a completely natural experience.

Stages and Symptoms of Culture Shock

Culture shock is not an exact process and will not look the same for any two people. There are various models for diagramming the culture shock experience such as Rhinesmith’s (1984) 10 Stages of Adjustment. In general, most people experience the following four phases of culture shock—sometimes more than once and in no exact order:

- **Honeymoon:** This phase describes when an individual is excited to embark on the new journey and open to trying new things. This stage also may have a bit of initial anxiety and nervousness as one prepares for experiencing a new culture.
- **Negotiation or Rejection:** This stage encompasses when cultural and language differences become apparent and frustrating, with a general feeling that something does not make sense alongside feelings of isolation. This stage is usually characterized by feelings of homesickness, confusion, anger, and loneliness.
- **Adjustment:** While some days are better than others, healthy adjustment can be supplemented with healthy routines, relationships, and access to the resources and activities listed below. It is common to experience days or moments of negotiation and rejection followed by adjustment—remember that culture shock is not a linear experience.
- **Recovery or Acceptance:** This is when individuals are feeling a sense of belonging in the new culture and finding contentment as a member of the community. In this phase, one feels a part of both cultures and can analyze both the home culture and new culture with a critical eye. Even in this stage, it is common to experience bouts of negotiation, rejection, and adjustment and it is important to continue to focus on healthy physical, emotional, and mental practices.

While culture shock is (almost) inevitable, intentional education before and during transition can help prepare participants with both setting expectations and accessing resources. People going through culture shock should be aware of the following resources to best prepare for the various potential highs and lows of the experience:

- Mental health resources (e.g., structured mental health support through telemedicine and mentored group sessions)

- Physical health activities (e.g., safe walking spaces or sports teams)
 - Identity-based reflection exercises to help understand personal cultural customs, norms, and expectations
 - Support structures with others going through the same experience or who have experience navigating new cultures
 - Connecting with the host culture through new relationships and interests (i.e., food, tourism, local sports, or hobbies)
-

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Re-Entry Shock

Re-entry shock is an adjustment period felt when someone returns to their “home” culture after time spent away. This period after returning requires intentional integration back into a home culture and is often met with feelings of disorientation, confusion, or frustration.

When people go abroad, they expect to feel a sense of culture shock as they are entering a foreign culture where they do not speak the local language, but few expect to experience an emotional adjustment shock upon re-entry to their home culture. This unexpected adjustment typically lacks societal awareness and preparation—as upon return, people may find less support and understanding within their previous comforting community. The dissonance of feeling foreign in a place that was once home can be startling and confusing to process.

Common symptoms of re-entry shock include:

- Feeling alienated from friends (e.g., they no longer understand you)
- Withdrawing from previous interests
- Feeling frustration with the home culture
- Feeling a strong desire to return abroad

These feelings typically are part of a generalized 3-part re-entry adjustment period. Various resources will use different names or categories but generally follow the same pattern:

- **Euphoria:** Much like the honeymoon period of culture shock, this stage is epitomized by the excitement of being home, seeing loved ones, and tasting foods you have not had the ability to be around since leaving the country.
- **Irritability and Hostility:** In this phase, the dissonance between home and host cultures are pronounced, which can produce feelings of alienation from friends and family as well as frustration with tasks and situations that were previously common.
- **Gradual Adjustment:** This period evens out the experience as an individual begins to see positives and negatives with both host and home cultures, identify with a hybrid of both cultures, and navigate more multicultural or hybrid settings.

Initiatives and Programming

As re-entry shock is common, even for a well-seasoned traveler, here are ways you can support individuals’ experiencing re-entry shock:

- Offer programs about re-entry shock prior to cultural transitions to help educate and bring awareness to the topic as you would with culture shock.

- Support social programming to bring people experiencing or who have recently experienced re-entry shock together through clubs and social activities.
- Ensure access to mental health services and therapy.
- Integrate returning individuals going through re-entry shock into programming such as study abroad fairs and international scholar programs where they can share their experiences and support others.
- Encourage reflective writing and mentorship programs.

While re-entry shock is something almost everyone who spends time outside of their culture experiences to an extent, research in and programming around re-entry shock is comparatively lacking.

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Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion and ICT

Despite what may seem to be obvious alignment, the fields of diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) and ICT often seem far apart. In fact, for much of their existence as distinct fields, practitioners and scholars in DEI and ICT have frequently worked, at best, in parallel and, at worst, at cross-purposes (particularly in the U.S. context).

Each field has valid critiques of as well as much to offer the other. In the last decade, there has been an increased emphasis on developing a more integrated approach, however, there still remains significant work to be done. One challenge is how to approach DEI work in a global context, particularly for those coming from a U.S. perspective. It is important to acknowledge that while this section of the ICT Toolkit was composed by someone coming from a U.S. perspective, we welcome additional thoughts and perspectives from outside the United States.

Basic Definitions

In acknowledging that there is frequently a lack of clarity around common definitions of key terms in DEI, here is one possible set to frame these terms:

- **Diversity** often refers to the multitude of characteristics that make someone unique including differences in terms of age, race, ethnicity, nationality, culture, gender identity, sexual orientation, language, religion, physical and mental ability, political affiliation, socioeconomic status, education, family and marital status, immigration status, etc.
- **Equity** refers to ensuring that practices, policies, and programs are established in a manner that promotes fair and just treatment (rather than simply equal treatment). While subjective, equity is frequently addressed by the creation of opportunities for historically underrepresented populations.
- **Inclusion** requires active engagement to ensure that not only are policies, practices, and programs equitable but also that all individuals have, and feel that they have, a seat at the table; that diverse individuals are welcomed and have a voice in the decisionmaking processes; and that the behaviors and cultural norms of an organization make diverse individuals feel welcome.
- **Belonging** is a term in increasing use and refers to the feeling or sense of being welcomed on the part of diverse individuals, as well as to what degree do the outcomes of the organizations DEI efforts result in the feeling of being welcomed.

Increasing the diversity of a group (i.e., student body, work group, field of study, department, etc.) is often the lowest hurdle to clear. Organizations may begin by simply seeking out and/or adding members of traditionally underrepresented groups, for

example. However, simply increasing the diversity of a group does not ensure that equity, inclusion, and belonging will follow.

Theories and Principles

The intercultural communication professional concerned with principles of DEI should have some basic understanding of the following:

- Critical Race Theory
- Decolonization Theory
- Indigenization Theory
- Pedagogy of the Oppressed
- Intersectionality
- Global Social Justice
- Understanding of institutionalized privilege, power, and positionality

Tensions & Critiques

The fields of DEI and ICT hold some well-founded critiques of each other. DEI critiques of ICT include that most theories of intercultural communication do not give enough weight or emphasis to questions of positionality, context, framing, or the impacts of colonialism. There are some frameworks (e.g., Sorrells's [2012] Intercultural Communication Praxis Model) that incorporate these questions but, with intentionality, similar questions could be incorporated into any intercultural communication model to explore issues of identity, power, privilege, stereotypes, and discrimination.

Additionally, while intercultural communication theories often share a basic recognition of culture at multiple levels, one critique of intercultural communication work in practice is that it often places an emphasis on “culture” as equivalent to nationality to the deficit of other important aspects of diversity. In order to avoid this pitfall, consider ways in which your intercultural communication practice may support the promotion of understanding different cultural groups (i.e., deaf culture, LGBTQ, etc.) It may also be helpful to explore the Identity section of this toolkit to consider how the intersectionality of identities impacts intercultural communication and understanding.

On the other hand, ICT critiques of DEI include that the field is often too “U.S.-centric.” It is important to understand that while issues of DEI exist across the globe, they do not always present in the same way as they do in the United States. Therefore, the appropriate responses or interventions may also be different. As professionals, we need to ask ourselves how can we approach issues of DEI in a global context and in a culturally appropriate way.

This question can even trip up DEI professionals from other parts of the world. In her book, *Leading Global Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion*, Anand (2022) shares her experience of coming to the realization that even though she had grown up in India and thought she understood the needs of working women in India, she was not successful until she dropped her U.S.-centric approach and asked participants about their needs. A further critique of DEI models by ICT professionals is that they may not incorporate developmentally-appropriate approaches.

These critiques are well-founded and, frankly, indicators that these two fields have much to learn from each other and would benefit from working together to develop approaches that address these critiques to build a stronger model.

On many college and university campuses, however, there has traditionally been some tension between DEI and ICT offices that may hamper efforts to work together. At many institutions, DEI is traditionally located within the Student Affairs Division, while ICT is often seated within Academic Affairs. This separation of the work can lead to tension in terms of both recognition and funding. Despite these tensions, it is increasingly clear that opportunities exist to incorporate DEI work and theories into ICT work and theories, and vice versa. And, it is increasingly important that we do so. As ICT professionals, we need to reach out to our counterparts in the DEI space to welcome their perspectives on our work and, just as importantly, to offer our support for their work.

Activities

Many activities designed for understanding identity, exploring cultural values, and communicating across cultures can easily be adapted to incorporate questions of power and context. Sorrells (2012), for example, offers a simple exercise called “Intercultural Praxis: Negotiating Differences” that includes a debrief that is a great place to start with participants. Although the questions are specifically designed to be used with students, they can easily be adapted for use with other audiences.

To incorporate privilege and power in activities that explore cultural values, ask: “Whose cultural scripts are centered?” and “What are the different impacts that centering has on people who share or don’t share those cultural scripts?” For example, when saying “let’s all brainstorm together,” we may be privileging those for whom that phrase is a native or fluent way of ideating, as well as putting extra bandwidth and emotional energy demands on others. Some of those additional demands may include: considering and coping with stereotype threat, navigating whether and how to accept or adjust viewpoints, and doing the work of assimilation or adaptation; this does not include offering potentially helpful ways of ideating and out-of-the-box thinking because they may not be well-received.

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Sample Agendas

Multipurpose Workshop

Whether you are offering a stand-alone introduction to intercultural communication, a day-long training, or a series, you may find it helpful to use this multipurpose workshop outline as a building block for training:

- **Introduction to trainer, participants, and topic** in order to build connection before focusing on content.
- **Icebreaker** to build energy, get people talking, facilitate introductions, activate prior knowledge, and build curiosity.
- **Train** an intercultural concept with a related intercultural skill.
- **Practice** skill.
- **Facilitate** discussion.
- **Action planning** to apply the concept and skill to participants' contexts.

One-Hour Introduction to Intercultural Communication

Sometimes a group, team, or class needs an introduction to intercultural communication as a stand-alone module within a larger program (e.g., new student or new employee orientation). This kind of introduction also helps as the first in a series of intercultural training workshops (see below). Either way, this sample agenda for a one-hour introduction to intercultural communication is a flexible outline for laying out the basics:

- **Introductions**
- **Icebreaker**—Be sure to make it meaningful! Use something like “Communication Struggle” to introduce the topic.
- **Define Culture**—Make sure to discuss the definitions of culture given above together. Consider using the iceberg and universal/personal/cultural activities from *Maximizing Study Abroad* (Paige et al. 2002).
- **Consider and Explain Misunderstandings**—Explore and focus on what can go wrong in intercultural communication. Utilize Barna's (1988) *Stumbling Blocks in Intercultural Communication* as an introduction.
- **Discuss Ideas**—Ideate and innovate ways to overcome identified stumbling blocks which apply to participants' situations.

Workshop Series

Many institutions offer a series of workshops that are aimed at achieving multiple learning outcomes over the course of weeks or a semester. An important training design decision is whether each workshop stands alone, encouraging more participation, or builds upon

content from the previous and allows a cohort of participants to build rapport and go deeper into subject matter. This sample outline for a series of four stand-alone, mutually reinforcing workshops is based on the AAC&U *Intercultural Knowledge and Competence VALUE Rubric*. Each workshop may be planned according to the multipurpose workshop outline above, incorporating intercultural concepts and skills mentioned.

- **Introduction to Intercultural Communication** (sample agenda above)—Incorporate elements of identity and the intersection with diversity, equity, and inclusion as outlined in their respective sections below.
- **Communication Styles**—Review and explore communication style dimensions self-assessments and activities such as those found in *Maximizing Study Abroad* (Paige et al. 2002).
- **Dimensions of Cultural Difference**—Discuss cultural frameworks by Storti, Hofstede, or others. Application can be made with Bennett’s (2009) Intercultural Positioning System.
- **Mindfulness in Intercultural Communication**—Use the mindfulness section of the NAFSA Intercultural Communication in Practice CEP Workshop or Berardo’s (2012) Describe-Analyze-Evaluate (DAE) activity.

Intercultural Discussion Group

A great starting point for an intercultural training program is a discussion group. As always, it is beneficial to poll participants to determine their interests, preferences, etc., but here is a sample structure to get started.

- **Select Participants**—Consider colleagues in your team, cross-functional colleagues from your institution/organization, student leaders, attendees from prior intercultural workshops, and current or potential intercultural trainers.
- **Select Materials**—Begin with a broad, introductory text like Meyer’s (2014) *The Culture Map* or Winter’s (2017) *We Can’t Talk About That at Work* to give some context. Going further can include branching out and alternating through other media such as fiction and nonfiction books, journal and popular articles, movies and documentaries, and podcasts and music.
- **Plan and Execute Meetings**—Connection before content is the rule here. First, get to know one another, build trust and rapport, and establish some ground rules for your meetings. Many participants find it helpful to have a list of questions or topics to think about before the meeting.

Study Abroad or In-Bound International Student Pre-Departure Orientation

Intercultural communication training has a definitive place in pre-departure orientation programming. While needs often tend toward the immediate, physical, and logistical

aspects, participants can benefit immensely from cultural preparation. Intercultural communication training can be included in orientation programming by being infused through the following four areas:

- **Icebreaker and Introductions**— Encourage participants to become familiar with the presenter and other participants, as well as providing an overview of topics covered throughout the orientation.
- **Required Information**—Deliver necessary information for participants regarding program administration, health, safety, and so on.
- **Intercultural Concepts and Skills**—Review topics as outlined above in relation to the participants’ personal cultural backgrounds and identities as well as the culture of the destination and its citizens. Consider resources and professionals familiar with the specific cultural, learning, and working environments.

References & Additional Resources

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Conclusion

This ICT Toolkit provides a primer for several key topics for early career professionals in international education, whether working at an institute of higher education, program provider, nonprofit organization, or other work environment. Although designed for the early career professional, we hope that it will be useful for any professional working with people from diverse cultural backgrounds and interested in increasing their own understanding of the intercultural communication field.

We would like to note several key points and charges to readers:

- The ICT Toolkit is an introductory document not a comprehensive overview of the field of intercultural communication. There are a wealth of resources (i.e., books, articles, websites, trainings, etc.) in this field, only a few of which are referenced in this document. Please use the Toolkit as a starting point and seek out additional resources and trainings.
- As a primer, the Toolkit does not cover all or even most of the topic areas that are important in understanding the field of intercultural communication. Please comment within the [ICT Network](#) with what other areas or topics you would like to see covered in a future or standalone document.
- The ICT Toolkit was written by a group of individuals from a largely western perspective and was further limited by restrictions of time and length. Please let the Teaching, Learning, and Scholarship Knowledge Community (tlskc@nafsa.org) know what additional resources and perspectives you have found to be helpful in your intercultural communication journey.

We have enjoyed working on this Toolkit and bringing it to fruition. Please engage with the resource, its authors, and each other using the Discussion forum for the [ICT Network](#).

Thank you!

2020–21 ICT Network Subcommittee